

Rebirth as Doctrine and Experience

His strong conviction about the truth of Buddhism gave him a certain advantage in the study of the cases in which respect I have felt myself at times deficient. He had become convinced of the essential truth of the Buddha's teaching when only sixteen years old. His acceptance of Buddhism then and later had nothing to do with evidence from case studies. This happened because first, there was little of such evidence available until we began our investigations, and secondly, because Buddhism's appeal to him in no way depended on evidence. He accepted Buddhism on rational rather than on empirical grounds. For me, on the other hand, the truth of Buddhism, and hence my acceptance of it, depended at least to some extent on whatever evidence of rebirth the investigation of the cases could generate. This attitude led me to treat the cases sometimes as if they were fragile and as if the loss of a case would lessen, if only by a little, my own wavering convictions about Buddhism. Not so Francis Story. For him all the evidence from the cases could have collapsed into nothing and he would have remained unshaken in his belief in the truth of the Buddha's teachings. With this background he approached the cases as a neutral and sometimes stern critic of informants. Discrepancies about details such as occur commonly enough in human testimony of the kind obtained in these cases vexed and occasionally angered him. He sometimes cross-examined witnesses in a manner that made the targets of his penetrating questions uncomfortable and observers wonder why he had not taken up the law as a profession. He had an unusual gift for pursuing small details, although he rarely allowed the lesser aspects of a case to decide his assessment of it as a whole.

Some persons may nevertheless think that his bias toward Buddhism could have influenced his interviews and his analysis of the data that emerged from them. From the observations that I could make of him during the many months we spent together I do not think this occurred. And this was so not only because, as I have said above, he was rather indifferent to the outcome of the investigation of any single case—although not to the research as a whole—but also because he had the detachment of the true scientist. (This is a virtue in Buddhism also and his Buddhism made him a better scientist.) He always gave facts primacy over theory and when some element of a case conflicted with what Buddhist teachings had led him to expect he unhesitatingly questioned the teaching rather than the data, provided that he had satisfied himself of their authenticity. I need hardly add to the probable readers of this book that the Buddha himself taught us to learn by our own experiences rather than accept on faith anyone else's statements—including his own. And Francis Story found nothing incompatible between Buddhism